

From the Ground Up: Inside a Grassroots Psychedelic Conference

A report from the Psychonauticon Conference in Brno

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I really love Vienna. For me, living for almost half a year without leaving a conservative, monumental city is not difficult at all. I swear.

For this exact reason, when I received a message from a good acquaintance about a psychedelic conference in the Czech Republic, I didn't even wait for an actual invitation. They say that our brain (soul, ego, essence, or whatever else it might be) already knows our next steps long before we consciously process them. Well, I knew right away that by the end of November, I would be sitting in the small city of Brno, surrounded by people I had never met before. A quick search on a simple but stylish website called Psychonauticon 2025, and the slogan caught my eye: "Join us for an inspiring gathering at the intersection of science, culture, and consciousness." Beautiful - and somehow confusingly abstract. But I love adventures - and, as it would later turn out, it was not for nothing that I felt so strongly drawn to this one.

I secured my spot simply, though slowly: through correspondence with a frequency of one email every seven working days. I felt sentimental about this familiar classic: the organizational tempo of small events held together only by volunteers and a good portion of pure goodwill. In the end, for being added to some kind of approved participants' list, I paid around 35 euros for two days. An incredible offer for an event that could, in theory, change my understanding of reality. How can you even try to measure potential abstract gains in the form of knowledge, connections, emotions, and insights using a shaky capitalist unit of value?

But what kind of conference is this, exactly? Digging a little deeper on another lonely evening, I find the first major hook: this special event will celebrate the upcoming scientific psilocybin trials in the Czech Republic, set to begin next year. Now I feel the emotional contours of the trip beginning to take shape. I closely follow the development of the legal status of psychedelics - and oh boy, we do have some reasons to celebrate. Apart from Australia and Switzerland, long considered progressive, some U.S. states have recently followed suit, allowing licensed psilocybin services for adults over 21 in supervised environments. Also, in March 2025, the Ukrainian Ministry of Health laid the foundation for scientific research with psychedelics, aiming toward evidence-based policy and allowing medical treatment for veterans and civilians recovering from war trauma. Now we just need to reschedule the drugs from the most restrictive category -easy-peasy (we as in we,

Ukrainians). A bit later, in June 2025, New Zealand approved the prescription of medicinal psilocybin for treating depression. And now - the Czech Republic joins in as well. Each and every event - its own reason to celebrate. Thus, it's good that the schedule includes not only lectures, but also parties. Two of them, to be precise - on Saturday and Sunday. "An interesting choice," I think to myself, and continue browsing the website.

"...in partnership with PsychedeliCare" - the second hook. I know this organization, and I even volunteered for them for a brief period of time, which I strangely remember almost nothing about. The organization was founded in 2023 by Théo Giubilei, a French guy based in Brussels with a background in European politics, from what I read. Today, the organization has more than 400 members in over 20 countries (as they state on their website; but some of them are my dear friends, so I do believe those numbers). In 2024, PsychedeliCare officially registered a European Citizens' Initiative calling for safe, regulated access to psychedelic-assisted therapy and for support of scientific research freed from cultural stigma. This idea was met with great appreciation from many respected old-school psychedelic activist organizations, such as PAREA, Psychedelics Europe, and the French Society of Psychedelics - in other words, one for all, and all for one: PsychedeliCare was positively recognized within the circle of psychedelic grassroots organizations.

Well, you can never prepare enough for a conference, and using this excuse, I close the website and thus my search - deciding to let everything else just drift. Whatever happens, happens. On the next day, after just two hours away, I'm at the train station in Brno, a city that, after Vienna, feels like a breath of fresh air and draws you in with its honesty and simplicity. An almost esoteric place of power, a small free city - and also one of the centers of the Theosophical Society's gatherings in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. A city that is just a stone's throw away from a clinic where the sadly internationally underappreciated psychiatrist Milan Hausner (1929–2000) actively used LSD in individual and group psychotherapy long before it became mainstream - back in the days of Czechoslovakia, in the 1960s and 1970s. A clinic where he conducted more than 3,000 sessions. One of the most experienced and remarkable advocates of psychedelic use. The clinic, by the way, is still operating - and has 4.1 stars from 17 Google reviews, one of which simply reads: "very romantic place."

I walk, admiring the small streets, parks, and wrought-iron fences that seem to speak Czech, when right next to me, behind a woven hedge, a sight appears - half dump, half abstraction: a pile of boards, pieces of wood, someone's jacket, one boot, and something that seems to have once been a baby stroller. In short, an incredibly conceptual picture. "This could have been a pavilion at the Viennale," I think to myself without a trace of irony. "But come on, could it really...? No way!" Right next to it, a very low, formerly purely technical building suddenly emerges, now painted in

an exquisitely modern, liberally purple color. I check Google Maps and - you guessed it - I am exactly at the appointed place. How else could it be? Piled up, cluttered with abandoned objects, concealed beneath heaps of wood, under the urban history of the city - a space for hidden, occult knowledge (Latin: *occulere* to cover over, conceal, hide). "Ring," says the word on the wall, and right next to it, for clarity, an arrow is drawn pointing to the doorbell. For a second, I feel like Alice, and gathering the courage to become either taller or smaller, I ring.

The door was opened to me by a flustered-looking guy, clearly not very happy that I had rung the bell - no surprise, since I was at least three hours late. He disappears somewhere into a maze of corridors, and I follow the trail he leaves behind like the White Rabbit, finding myself in a space where I am immediately washed over by a sense of shared values. Just like that, right from the threshold. Simply from the fact that not a single head turned in my direction when the door creaked as I entered, but instead, almost enchanted - or rather, "as if not from this reality" - everyone remained intensely focused on the podium.

The ceiling was very low - and, in the best traditions of contemporary spaces for contemporary free people, people were already seated on stylish wooden chairs in front of a low podium with a chair for the presenter. The sense of freedom lived in the self-made (and partly unfinished) design - no wallpaper, walls covered with pages torn out of books; a PVC kitchen; a refrigerator that has probably seen more parties than I have in my entire life; draped fabrics in the style of psytrance gatherings; and, of course, a board with four clocks - London, Shanghai, New York, and Tokyo. All of them were turned upside down, and to my great disappointment, not a single one was working. This eclectic mix of styles, although slightly disorienting at first, had one undeniable advantage - it suited everyone present, and everyone present suited it. As I later found out, this place was chosen "in a last-minute despair - and also because it's grungy and underground, exactly as I like it," the organizer said. "I was very happy, because I am always looking for new sexy locations."

For these two days, presenters gathered from five countries: a bunch of PhD researchers, practical investigators, independent proactive activists, and artists. It turned into a vivid tapestry of topics - from years of therapeutic practice and historical perspectives on esotericism and occultism, through the practical use of psychedelics in journalism, a.k.a. gonzo journalism, to conceptual explorations of philosophical narratives. Everything scientific, everything grounded. Yet all the researchers officially came from different fields - some universities had pushed the topic of psychedelics into philosophy departments, some into anthropology, others into psychology, and some even into faculties of religious studies. I guess it's only logical - how can one possibly taxonomize such an all-encompassing matter?

Previously, when I spoke with people outside the circle interested in psychedelics, the idea of "being alternative" often surfaced in conversations. Alternative thinking,

alternative movements, alternative knowledge. And this gathering at first also felt somehow alternative - and for me personally, that would not be a very positive description. I have always had a question: how can a movement position itself as being “against” something? As an alternative to something? In this way, self-positioning does not emerge from within, but from the necessity of having something to oppose - and therefore, after the disappearance of that something, it holds the potential for a deafening collapse. Yet after a few hours, I stopped seeing the surface-level “alternativeness” and began to see substance and cohesion. This cohesion seemed to come from within a shared, grounded philosophical understanding, rather than from the presence of a common enemy outside. That is how it happens - cohesion within society at some point grows, swells, passes a certain mathematical threshold - and ceases to be “alternative,” even for a broader audience.

After the first block of lectures - the first long break. Outside it was wet and cold, yet in the courtyard an iron bathtub stacked with logs was already prepared. Someone tried to start a fire; it absolutely refused to catch. Yet even without the life-giving fire, conversations unfolded around its placeholder. There are spaces and encounters where small talk is not needed. Where, from the very first words, you feel unexpectedly safe, even while being intensely and directly asked about the essence of your self. Where the social tango of surface conversations is consciously skipped, the one during which you are supposed to determine whether you share a common vision. In this space, the invitation was immediately toward an exchange of insights, toward change. It was surprisingly simple and unspeakably complex at the same time. To my own surprise, I caught myself thinking that this space felt like one of the most intimate gatherings I had ever been to.

On the evening of the first day, during the announced party, I managed to catch the ever-elusive Tancredi, the main organizer. He is a vivid representative of that type of person you see for the first time, yet you have the persistent feeling that you have already lived through several wild stories together that bonded you forever. He, a Ph.D. researcher in Religious Studies at Masaryk University in Brno, a part of the PsychedeliCare Network, and a cool guy, completely immersed himself in his role as the host of a small conference.

“What was I thinking, putting parties into the schedule for both days - Saturday and Sunday?” he said, laughing.

I wasn’t going to waste time. I had questions.

“The reason for this event? I just wanted to shake off academia; often, the way knowledge is presented during scientific conferences is boring and not that

immersive. The way it happens now is that people just talk dryly from a stage - and not always successfully. But as Gerardus van der Leeuw, a phenomenologist of religion, said, knowledge should “acquire its place in the life of the student himself, who should understand it out of his inner self.” My goal is to put humanity back into the humanities.”

When asked why he decided to organize Psychonauticon now, Tancredi didn't hesitate: “Many people in the field of psychedelic research don't know what to do with their studies - whereas I decided to use my knowledge and try to put something together, and most importantly, to do it exactly the way I like it. I believe in the transcendent value of research on psychedelics.”

From his own words, he managed to build a bit of a weirdo reputation by investing in conferences, travelling, and networking rather than publishing papers; this approach made his own conference possible - the fellow researchers he connected with over the years, upon invitation, simply decided to gamble on taking part in Psychonauticon.

“Funding came entirely out of my own pocket. Luckily enough, I broke even,” he laughed. “Overall, it was just a race I decided to jump into - because I felt that if I don't start it now, I'll never do it.”

The second day was no less intense. It began with a trip to the forest for a morning meditation and connection with nature. “Take a deep breath. Listen to the sounds around you - the rustling leaves and the birds singing.” Yet around us, it was very quiet; only a dog was barking very loudly. I slowly breathed in, calm but a bit excited for the lectures ahead. Then we returned to the already familiar space, and a new portion of input for reflection awaited us - new conversations, new insights.

I won't describe everything, because that would turn this article into a novel. Still, these two days left me with a new and rather fundamental question. What is a psychedelic experience? Could all of this be it? Are all of us - all 40 participants of the first conference of this kind in Brno - ourselves the physical part of what we are studying? A fractal beginning with itself and spiralling inward?

Ironically enough, here too society seems to have come full circle: from around 10,000 scientific publications between 1943 and 1970 - enough for psychedelics to be described as “the most intensively researched pharmacological substance ever” by Oxford University Press - through moral panic and prohibition. One of many telling examples is the Vancouver School Board's 1967 bulletin “Dangers of LSD,” warning that “case histories show a slipping in achievement in every phase of life” among LSD users. This narrative eventually led to the classification of LSD as a Schedule I drug and to the beginning of the war on drugs. And now, once again, we are looping back: a renewed popular movement, the creation of organizations, the registration of

a European Citizens' Initiative, and a growing number of articles in international journals on the topic since the early 2000s.

Yet our time can also be described as a wave of spiritual nihilism confronting Western civilization. The old systems of meaning no longer fully work, yet nothing stable has truly replaced them. Religion became private, politics turned performative, communities fragmented, and endless consumption began masquerading as identity. People are left searching for something capable of breaking through the numbness of contemporary life - something that still feels sacred, transformative, or simply real. It is therefore not surprising that this growing interest in spirituality and "hidden" ways back to the roots also evolves into the phenomenon of psychedelic capitalism - when those who possess resources attempt to fill the vacuum created by the culture's crisis of meaning. The psychedelic field has already become a dizzying marketplace for mass consumption, offering an excess of publications, podcasts, festivals, nonprofit organizations, conferences, self-proclaimed gurus, resort centers, and exclusive retreats catering to elite clientele. Yet even in the medical field, the race is already unfolding in full force. Companies such as Compass Pathways and Mindset Pharma are rushing to secure patents on what they describe as "novel" psychedelic substances, therapeutic models, and manufacturing methods.

Yet beneath the optimistic language of innovation and progress lies a far more uncomfortable question: who actually owns psychedelics? Indigenous communities carried and protected many forms of psychedelic knowledge long before Western laboratories rediscovered them and translated them into the language of biotech, wellness, and venture capital. Today, the transformation of these practices into privately owned assets increasingly provokes accusations of biopiracy - the extraction of traditional knowledge, stripped from its cultural roots and repackaged for profit without compensation or meaningful recognition.

And the money flowing into the psychedelic gold rush is already impossible to ignore. The future of psychedelic-assisted therapy is gradually becoming shaped not only by scientists, therapists, and activists, but also by investors, shareholders, and market competition. In April this year, after President Donald Trump himself signed an executive order easing the approval process for psychedelic drugs, the stock of Compass Pathways reportedly surged by more than 40 percent almost overnight.

And what can one say - even academic conferences on psychedelics are heavily monetized. While writing this article, I conducted a small experiment: in 30 minutes, I found 12 on-site psychedelic conferences across seven different countries happening within the next six months. Two of them, curiously enough, are taking place in New Orleans at the same time. Tickets range from 400 euros to 2,000 euros per participant. Research and publicity are good, I know. But these large conferences, with prices higher than my monthly rent, certainly feel like a form of gatekeeping.

This article did not come easily to me, especially because while researching the previous two paragraphs about the commodification of psychedelics, I began to feel strangely confined. Will biotechnology start-ups that are already raising substantial capital for clinical trials, while investors and venture capitalists scope possible multibillion-dollar mass-market profits, eventually reach even my own little corner of the world? Yet every time these thoughts became too heavy, I remembered my trip to the conference - and suddenly calmed down again.

I realized something very important and, as it usually happens, very simple. Psychedelic experience, occult knowledge, symbolism, and tradition do not survive through capital. They survive through cultural undercurrents, communities, accidental conversations, and shared experiences. And perhaps the strongest and most powerful tool is simply remaining open to discourse on psychedelics for the sake of ordinary human curiosity. To research the history, to talk about experiences, to stay interested, and to share - not because it serves some greater purpose, not because it is profitable, not because it will heal the world, end wars, or return us to some manufactured state of happiness - but because it is, quite simply and very humanly, interesting.

And it is precisely at such small conferences that the hidden everyday magic of psychedelics stays alive. Perhaps this is exactly why grassroots spaces matter so much. Strange little conferences in hidden buildings, underground artists, local gatherings, support circles, people talking honestly until three in the morning - these fragile, chaotic, deeply alive spaces still protect something that cannot be patented or fully commercialized. Something collective. Something almost sacred. So, if we as humanity are already learning to approach ecology, climate, and mental health more consciously, perhaps we should approach the cultural discourse surrounding psychedelics with the same awareness - beginning at the grassroots level.

And so, if you have read this far, I want to give you a small push to turn you into an activist in just a few sentences. Open your search engine and look for a psychedelic event in your city. Or find an artist working with psychedelic or occult themes. Talk to people. Find a community. And if you cannot find one, perhaps create it yourself. Or maybe just come to Brno in the fall. The event is already online. Because, as simple as it sounds, these actions are exactly what shapes the abstract movement and not so abstract future of psychedelics.